CLOUD & DEVOPS

SRE Practices Visual Guide

Toil budgets, error budgets, blameless reviews — engineering reliability as a discipline.

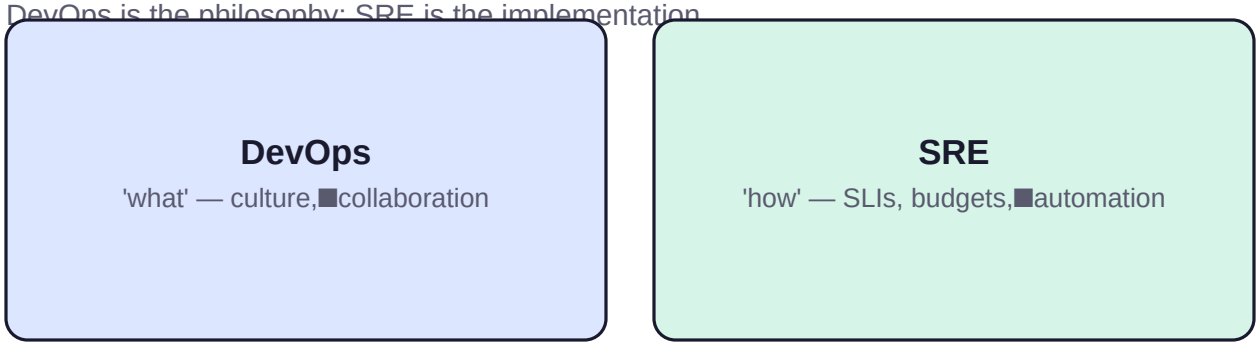
ANIMATED WALKTHROUGH

Step through pages to play the animation

STEP 1/6

DevOps vs SRE

DevOps is the philosophy; SRE is the implementation



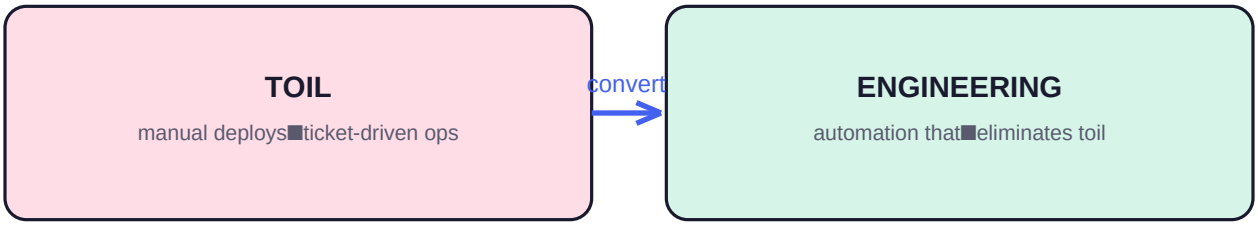
'SRE is what happens when you ask a software engineer to do operations.'

- SRE teams treat operations as a software problem: code the toil away.
- Reliability is a feature — budgeted, measured, and negotiated like any other.
- Shared ownership: devs own their services in prod; SRE provides the platform and practices.

STEP 2/6

Toil: The Work That Must Die

Toil = manual, repetitive, automatable, no enduring value.



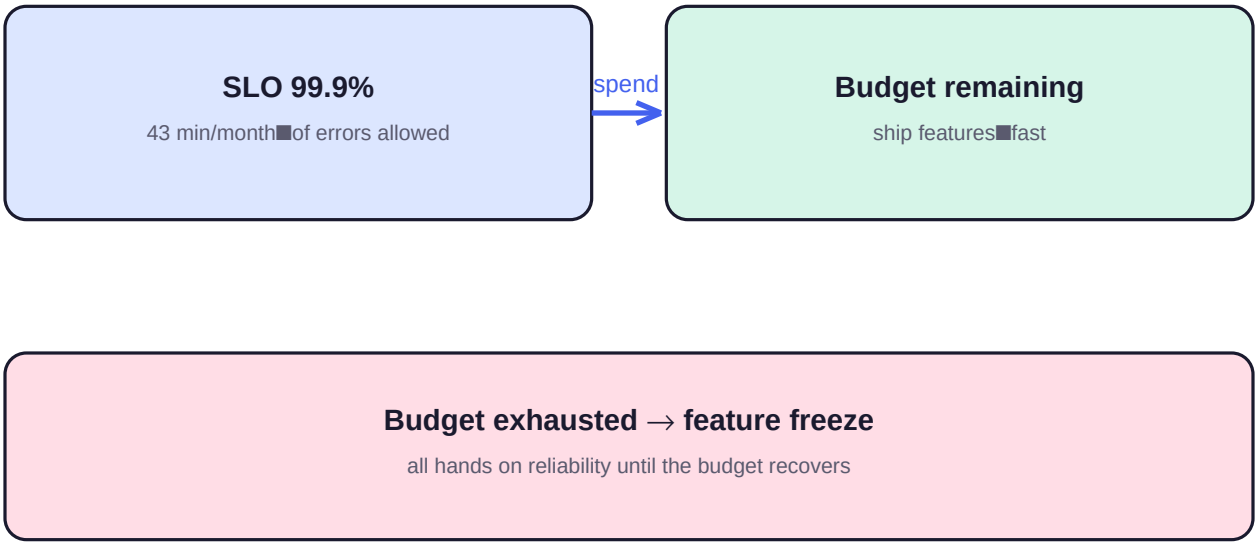
The 50% rule: SREs spend at most half their time on ops work — the rest on engineering.

- If toil exceeds 50%, the team stops taking on new services until it's fixed.
- Toil scales with the fleet; engineering scales the TEAM. Only one of these is sustainable.
- Measure toil in a weekly log — what gets measured gets automated.

STEP 3/6

Error Budgets: Permission to Move Fast

100% reliability is the wrong target — budgets make the tradeoff explicit.

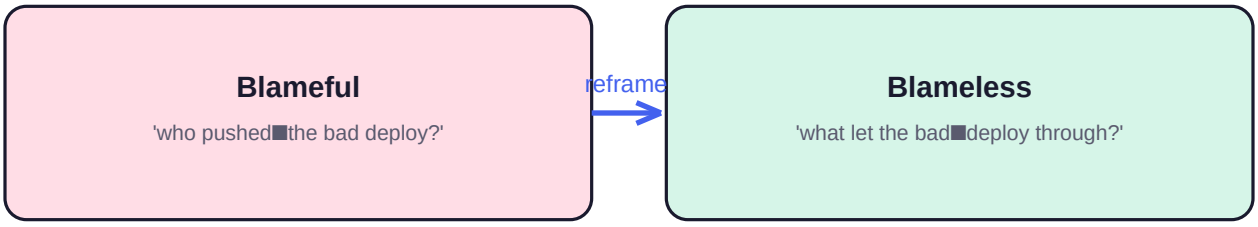


The budget aligns incentives: product wants velocity, SRE wants stability — the number settles the argument.

STEP 4/6

Blameless Postmortems

Fix the system, not the person — or nobody will tell you what broke.



- Assume everyone acted reasonably with the information they had.
- Ask 'how' five times: the deploy broke prod → why did CI pass? → why no canary? → …
- Action items have owners and dates — a postmortem without follow-through is theater.

Write it for the next on-call at 3am: timeline, root causes, what we changed so it can't recur.

STEP 5/6

Automation Over Toil: Examples

Every manual ritual is an automation candidate.

Deploys

one-button / fully automated with canary analysis

On-call triage

runbooks as code: auto-diagnose, suggest, then page

Capacity

autoscaling + predictive — no 2am 'add nodes' tickets

Releases

feature flags + progressive delivery, no deploy windows

STEP 6/6

SRE Team Topologies

How SRE plugs into the org without becoming a ticket queue.

Embedded

SREs inside product teams — reliability by pairing

Consulting

central team advises, builds platforms, reviews designs

Platform

SRE owns the paved road: CI/CD, observability, guardrails

Anti-pattern: SRE as 'ops ticket queue.' If SRE only does toil, it's not SRE — it's ops with a new name.

STEP ✓/✓

Key Takeaways

SRE Practices — Remember

- SRE implements DevOps: reliability as software engineering, measured and budgeted.
- Toil is manual, repetitive, automatable work — cap it at 50%, automate the rest.
- Error budgets turn 'move fast vs be stable' from argument into arithmetic.
- Blameless postmortems fix systems: five whys, owned action items, written for 3am.
- Never be a ticket queue: embed, consult, or platform — automate the toil away.

Keep exploring

Pair this guide with the matching video walkthroughs
and hands-on labs at interstitiumlabs.dev